Matoshri College of Engineering and Research Centre

Department of Engineering Sciences

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Submitted By:

Mansi Subhash Zalte

Roll Number**:** 60

Teacher Name:

Ms.Reshma Kadale Mam

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1. Introduction

Solar energy stands as one of the most abundant and inexhaustible renewable energy sources available on Earth. The photovoltaic (PV) cell, which directly converts sunlight into electricity, has undergone remarkable transformation since its invention in 1954. Over the past seven decades, scientists and engineers have relentlessly pursued higher Power Conversion Efficiency (PCE) — the ratio of electrical output to incident solar energy — as the primary metric of solar cell performance.

This case study provides a comprehensive examination of the power conversion efficiency achieved across the three primary generations of solar cell technology. Beginning with the mature, silicon-based first-generation cells, progressing through the thin-film second generation, and culminating with the cutting-edge multi-junction and perovskite-based third-generation architectures, this report analyzes how material science innovations, device engineering, and new physical mechanisms have pushed the efficiency frontier forward.

As the global demand for clean energy accelerates in 2025, understanding the efficiency landscape of solar technologies is crucial for policymakers, engineers, and investors seeking to deploy optimal photovoltaic solutions.

2. Objectives

The primary objectives of this case study are as follows:

- To define and explain the concept of Power Conversion Efficiency (PCE) in photovoltaic cells.
- To review the historical development and current state-of-the-art PCE for first, second, and third-generation solar cells.
- To compare the efficiency benchmarks, material compositions, and key advantages of each solar cell generation.
- To analyze the factors — such as bandgap engineering, light trapping, and tandem architectures — that influence efficiency improvements.
- To assess the most recent record PCE values validated by authoritative bodies such as NREL and Fraunhofer ISE (2024–2025).

- To identify challenges, limitations, and future prospects for each generation in reaching or surpassing the Shockley-Queisser theoretical limit.

3. Case Description

3.1 What is Power Conversion Efficiency (PCE)?

Power Conversion Efficiency (PCE) is defined as the percentage of incident solar power that is converted into electrical power by a photovoltaic device. It is expressed as:

$$\mathrm{PCE}\ (\%) = (P_{max} / P_{incident}) \times 100$$

Where P_{max} is the maximum electrical power output of the cell (in watts) and $P_{incident}$ is the total incident solar irradiance (standardized at 1000 W/m^2 under AM1.5G spectrum). The Shockley-Queisser limit sets a theoretical maximum PCE of approximately 33.7% for a single-junction solar cell under standard conditions.

3.2 Classification of Solar Cell Generations

Solar cells are broadly classified into three generations based on their material composition, fabrication technology, and the underlying physical mechanisms exploited for energy conversion. Each generation represents a distinct technological paradigm with its own efficiency profile, cost structure, and application domain.

4. Analysis

4.1 First-Generation Solar Cells (Crystalline Silicon)

First-generation solar cells, based on crystalline silicon (c-Si), represent the oldest and most commercially dominant photovoltaic technology. They are subdivided into monocrystalline silicon (mono-Si) and polycrystalline silicon (poly-Si) variants. Monocrystalline cells are fabricated from a single, continuous silicon crystal grown via the Czochralski process, yielding superior electron mobility and higher PCE. Polycrystalline cells are cast from multiple silicon crystals, making them less expensive but somewhat less efficient.

As of 2024–2025, the record laboratory PCE for monocrystalline silicon solar cells stands at 29.4%, achieved by LONGi Green Energy — approaching the Shockley-Queisser theoretical limit of 33.7%. Commercial mono-Si panels routinely achieve 22–24% efficiency. The introduction of passivated emitter and rear cell (PERC), tunnel oxide passivated contact (TOPCon), and heterojunction (HJT) technologies has driven efficiency gains in recent years. Polycrystalline silicon cells maintain commercial efficiencies of 17–20%.

4.2 Second-Generation Solar Cells (Thin-Film Technologies)

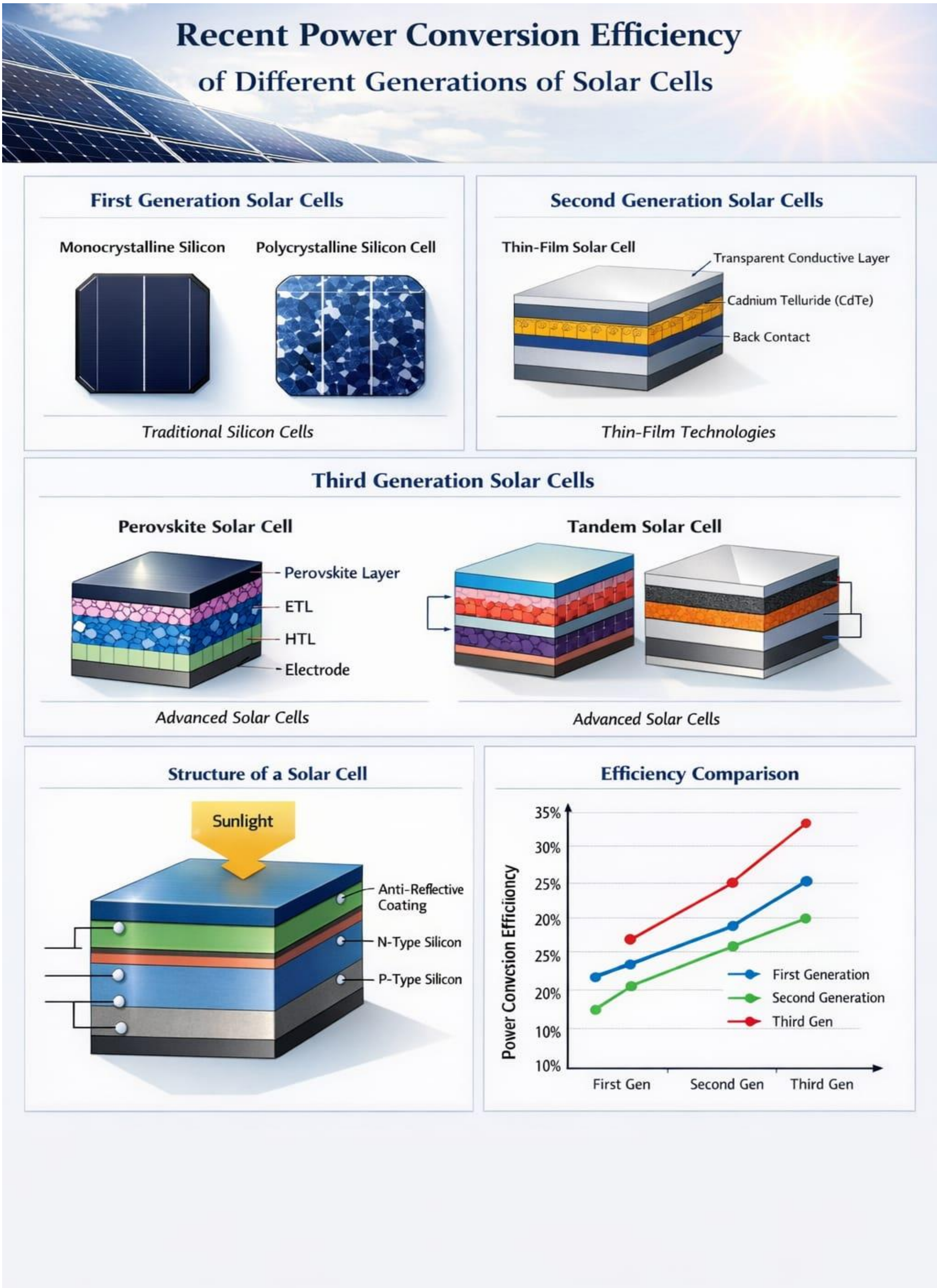
Second-generation cells were developed to address the high material cost and energy-intensive manufacturing of c-Si cells by using thin semiconductor films (1–4 micrometers thick) deposited on inexpensive substrates such as glass, metal foil, or plastic. The three dominant thin-film technologies are: Cadmium Telluride (CdTe), Copper Indium Gallium Selenide (CIGS), and Amorphous Silicon (a-Si).

CdTe cells hold the thin-film record of 22.1% (laboratory) and achieve 18–20% in commercial modules as of 2025. CIGS cells have demonstrated a record PCE of 23.35% (Empa, 2023), with commercial modules reaching 15–18%. Amorphous silicon, while the least efficient at 6–10% for single-junction, offers flexibility and semi-transparency for building-integrated applications.

4.3 Third-Generation Solar Cells (Emerging and Advanced Technologies)

Third-generation solar cells are designed to overcome the Shockley-Queisser single-junction limit through novel physical mechanisms. This generation encompasses perovskite cells, multi-junction concentrator cells, organic photovoltaics (OPV), quantum dot cells, and dye-sensitized solar cells (DSSC).

Perovskite solar cells achieved a remarkable efficiency trajectory from 3.8% (2009) to a certified record of 26.1% for single-junction perovskite cells as of 2024. Perovskite-silicon tandem cells achieved a certified record of 33.9% in 2024, surpassing the single-junction Shockley-Queisser limit. Multi-junction concentrator cells hold the overall world record at 47.6% efficiency under 2000-sun concentration (Fraunhofer ISE, 2022). Organic photovoltaics (OPV) have reached approximately 19% in laboratory conditions, while quantum dot cells show promise with approximately 18% efficiency.


Recent Power Conversion Efficiency
of Different Generations of Solar Cells
First Generation Solar Cells
Monocrystalline Silicon
Polycrystalline Silicon Cell
Traditional Silicon Cells
Second Generation Solar Cells
Thin-Film Solar Cell
Transparent Conductive Layer
Cadnium Telluride (CdTe)
Back Contact
Thin-Film Technologies
Third Generation Solar Cells
Perovskite Solar Cell
Perovskite Layer
ETL
HTL
Electrode
Advanced Solar Cells
Tandem Solar Cell
Advanced Solar Cells
Structure of a Solar Cell
Sunlight
Anti-Reflective Coating
N-Type Silicon
P-Type Silicon
Efficiency Comparison
35%
30%
25%
20%
25%
20%
10%
10%
Power Convcsion Efficiiency
First Gen
Second Gen
Third Gen
First Generation
Second Generation
Third Gen

4.4 Comparative Efficiency Summary Table

Solar Cell Type	Generation	Lab Record PCE	Commercial PCE	Year
Monocrystalline Si (HJT/TOPCon)	1st Gen	29.4%	22–24%	2024
Polycrystalline Si	1st Gen	23.3%	17–20%	2024
CdTe (Thin-Film)	2nd Gen	22.1%	18–20%	2025
CIGS (Thin-Film)	2nd Gen	23.35%	15–18%	2023
Amorphous Si	2nd Gen	14.0%	6–10%	2024
Perovskite (Single Junction)	3rd Gen	26.1%	18–22%	2024
Perovskite-Si Tandem	3rd Gen	33.9%	~28%	2024
III-V Multi-Junction (CPV)	3rd Gen	47.6%	35–40%	2022
Organic PV (OPV)	3rd Gen	~19%	10–14%	2023
Quantum Dot Cells	3rd Gen	~18%	Research Stage	2024

Table 1: Power Conversion Efficiency Summary — Solar Cell Generations (2022–2025)

5. Findings

5.1 Efficiency Trends Across Generations

The analysis reveals a clear progression in laboratory PCE from first to third-generation solar cells, with the most dramatic recent advances occurring in perovskite and tandem architectures. First-generation crystalline silicon remains the commercial workhorse, with high efficiency and long operational lifetimes of 25–30 years. However, efficiency gains from c-Si are approaching fundamental physical limits.

Second-generation thin-film technologies offer a cost-efficiency trade-off that is well-suited for utility-scale deployments, particularly in hot climates. The CIGS record of 23.35% demonstrates that thin-film technologies continue to improve. Third-generation technologies, particularly the perovskite-silicon tandem with a certified 33.9% PCE, have surpassed the single-junction theoretical limit. The primary challenge for perovskites remains long-term stability, with leading devices now demonstrating stability exceeding 1,000 hours under standard testing conditions.

5.2 Key Efficiency-Boosting Mechanisms

- TOPCon & HJT Architecture: Passivation of surface recombination losses in silicon cells has pushed mono-Si close to its theoretical PCE ceiling.
- Bandgap Engineering: Tuning perovskite composition allows optimal bandgap alignment for tandem stacking with silicon (ideal bandgap ~1.7 eV for top cell).
- Light Trapping Structures: Nanostructured front surfaces and rear reflectors in thin-film and silicon cells reduce optical losses.
- Tandem/Multi-Junction Design: Stacking absorber layers with complementary bandgaps captures a broader solar spectrum, enabling cells to surpass the Shockley-Queisser limit.
- Carrier Selective Contacts: Advanced contact materials minimize electrical losses and improve fill factors in high-efficiency cells.

6. Recommendations

Based on the analysis and findings, the following recommendations are proposed:

1. **Prioritize Perovskite-Silicon Tandem R&D:** Given the record 33.9% PCE and ongoing stability improvements, government and industry funding should be directed toward accelerating commercialization of tandem cells.
2. **Maintain Silicon Manufacturing Leadership:** The TOPCon and HJT silicon platform remains commercially dominant. Investment in c-Si manufacturing with advanced cell architectures ensures energy security.
3. **Address Perovskite Stability and Scalability:** Research must focus on lead-free compositions and encapsulation strategies to achieve the 25-year operational lifetimes required for bankable commercial products.
4. **Leverage Thin-Film for Specific Applications:** CIGS and CdTe thin-film panels are ideal for utility-scale and building-integrated applications due to their low temperature coefficient and form factor flexibility.
5. **Develop Standardized Testing Protocols:** The PV community should establish unified, rigorous efficiency certification standards for emerging technologies to ensure comparability across research institutions.

7. Conclusion

This case study has demonstrated that solar photovoltaic technology is undergoing a period of extraordinary advancement. First-generation crystalline silicon cells, despite being commercially mature, continue to push their efficiency boundaries through advanced passivation techniques, with laboratory records of 29.4%. Second-generation thin-film technologies offer viable alternatives with competitive efficiencies of up to 23.35% (CIGS) and manufacturing cost advantages that make utility-scale solar energy increasingly affordable.

The most transformative development in the field is the rapid rise of third-generation perovskite-silicon tandem solar cells, which achieved a certified 33.9% power conversion efficiency in 2024 — surpassing the theoretical single-junction limit for the first time in commercially relevant architectures. This milestone, combined with accelerating stability improvements, positions perovskite-silicon tandems as the leading candidate technology for the next generation of commercial solar modules.

The trajectory of solar cell efficiency improvements, driven by materials innovation, advanced device physics, and manufacturing excellence, strongly supports the continued decline in the levelized cost of electricity (LCOE) from photovoltaics. As these technologies mature and achieve cost parity at commercial scale, solar energy is positioned to fulfill a central role in the global transition to a clean, sustainable energy future.

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